

Neither flattened into predictability nor frozen in nostalgia, Poland feels remarkably vibrant today. During several weeks spent there recently, I started to notice a country subtly recalibrating itself through culture, architecture, and the stories it chooses to tell about its past.

WARSAW, CAPITAL LOGIC

After decades of destruction, reconstruction, and ideological transition, Warsaw is no longer reacting to history but shaping how that history is read. This shift becomes visible on Defilad Square. The newly opened Museum of Modern Art places art, film, design, and performance directly opposite the Palace of Culture and Science, the Stalin-era tower long associated with the imposition of Soviet power. Rather than erasing that inheritance, the city has chosen to place contemporary culture in conversation with it. Inside the Palace of Culture and Science, the Neon Museum displays restored Cold War-era neon signs. Once instruments of state messaging, they now appear as objects of design history and fragments of urban memory.